algorithms to ‘human nature’. They argue that it is human nature that produces all the hate and lies on the platforms. The tech giants then claim that due to their commitment to free-speech values, they hesitate to censor the expression of genuine human emotions. For example, in 2019 the CEO of YouTube, Susan Wojcicki, explained, ‘The way that we think about it is: “Is this content violating one of our policies? Has it violated anything in terms of hate, harassment?” If it has, we remove that content. We keep tightening and tightening the policies. We also get criticism, just to be clear, [about] where do you draw the lines of free speech and, if you draw it too tightly, are you removing voices of society that should be heard? We’re trying to strike a balance of enabling a broad set of voices, but also making sure that those voices play by a set of rules that are healthy conversations for society.’[10]

A Facebook spokesperson similarly said in October 2021, ‘Like every platform, we are constantly making difficult decisions between free expressions and harmful speech, security and other issues … But drawing these societal lines is always better left to elected leaders.’[11] In this way, the tech giants constantly shift the discussion to their supposed role as moderators of human-produced content and ignore the active role their algorithms play in cultivating certain human emotions and discouraging others. Are they really blind to it?

Surely not. Back in 2016, an internal Facebook report discovered that ‘64 percent of all extremist group joins are due to our recommendation tools … Our recommendation systems grow the problem.’[12] A secret internal Facebook memo from August 2019, leaked by the whistleblower Frances Haugen, stated, ‘We have evidence from a variety of sources that hate speech, divisive political speech, and misinformation on Facebook and [its] family of apps are affecting societies around the world. We also have compelling evidence that our core product mechanics, such as virality, recommendations, and optimizing for engagement, are a significant part of why these types of speech flourish on the platform.’[13]

Another leaked document from December 2019 noted, ‘Unlike communication with close friends and family, virality is something new we have introduced to many ecosystems … and it occurs because we intentionally encourage it for business reasons.’ The document pointed out that ‘ranking content about higher stakes topics like health or politics based